

Word family: **boutique**

Base word: boutique

Part of speech: mainly **noun**, also widely used **attributively** before another noun

Pronunciation: /bu:'ti:k/ — roughly **boo-TEEK**

Unlike families such as **rule** or **profit**, **boutique** has very few productive derivatives. Its richness comes mainly from **compound and extended uses**.

Core modern uses:

- * **boutique** (n.) — 精品店；時裝精品店；小型專門店
- * **boutique** (attributive adj.) — 精品式的；小型專門的；高端而具特色的
- * **fashion boutique** — 時裝精品店
- * **designer boutique** — 設計師品牌精品店
- * **clothing boutique** — 服裝精品店
- * **bridal boutique** — 婚紗精品店
- * **independent boutique** — 獨立精品店
- * **online boutique** — 網上精品店
- * **boutique hotel** — 精品酒店
- * **boutique firm** — 小型專門公司
- * **boutique consultancy** — 精品 / 小型專業顧問公司
- * **boutique law firm** — 精品 / 專門律師事務所
- * **boutique investment bank** — 精品投資銀行；專門投資銀行
- * **boutique agency** — 小型專門代理 / 顧問公司
- * **boutique brand** — 精品 / 小眾特色品牌
- * **boutique service** — 小型、高度個人化的專業服務
- * **boutique approach** — 小規模、專門化、個人化的做法

Meaning in this passage

> Unlike shoppers in a physical **boutique**, our customers cannot try on a dress, feel the fabric or compare two sizes in front of a mirror.

Here, **boutique** means:

a relatively small shop, especially one selling fashionable or carefully selected clothing and accessories — 精品店；時裝精品店

The writer contrasts:

shopping in a physical boutique

with

shopping online.

In a boutique, a customer can physically:

- * try clothing on,
- * touch the fabric,
- * inspect colour and quality,
- * compare different sizes,
- * look in a mirror,
- * sometimes receive personal assistance.

中文翻譯：

與在實體**時裝精品店 / 精品店**購物的顧客不同，我們的網上顧客不能試穿裙子、觸摸布料，或站在鏡子前比較兩個尺碼。

So here:

boutique = 規模通常較小、主打時裝或精選商品的實體零售店

A. BOUTIQUE = SMALL FASHIONABLE SHOP

1. **boutique = small fashionable shop — 精品店；時裝精品店**

This is the **exact passage sense** and the core dictionary meaning.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> Unlike shoppers in a physical **boutique**, our customers cannot try on a dress.

與在實體**時裝精品店**購物的人不同，我們的顧客不能試穿裙子。

Practice 2

> She bought the dress from a small **boutique** in Central.

她在中環一間小型**時裝精品店**買了這條裙。

Practice 3

> The boutique sells clothing from independent designers.

這間**精品店**出售獨立設計師的服裝。

MCQ-ready definition:

boutique = 規模較小、通常出售時尚、精選或具特色商品的零售店

2. **fashion boutique — 時裝精品店**

Practice 1

> She owns a **fashion boutique**.

她經營一間**時裝精品店**。

Practice 2

> The fashion boutique specialises in contemporary womenswear.

這間**時裝精品店**專售現代女裝。

3. **clothing boutique — 服裝精品店**

Practice 1

> The street is lined with independent **clothing boutiques**.

這條街有很多獨立**服裝精品店**。

Practice 2

> The clothing boutique offers a carefully selected range of garments.

這間**服裝精品店**提供精心挑選的服裝系列。

4. **designer boutique — 設計師品牌精品店**

Practice 1

> The mall contains several **designer boutiques**.

商場內有數間**設計師品牌精品店**。

Practice 2

> She visited a designer boutique to try on the coat.

她到一間**設計師精品店**試穿外套。

MCQ-ready definition:

designer boutique = 主要出售特定設計師 / 高端設計品牌商品的小型專門店

5. **luxury boutique — 奢侈品精品店**

Practice 1

> The district is known for its **luxury boutiques**.

該區以多間**奢侈品精品店**聞名。

Practice 2

> Luxury boutiques often emphasise personal service.

奢侈品精品店往往非常重視個人化服務。

6. **independent boutique — 獨立精品店**

A very common modern retail collocation.

Practice 1

> She prefers shopping at **independent boutiques**.

她較喜歡在**獨立精品店**購物。

Practice 2

> Independent boutiques may carry products that large chains do not stock.

獨立精品店可能出售大型連鎖店沒有的商品。

MCQ-ready definition:

independent boutique = 不屬於大型連鎖集團、通常自行選貨和營運的精品小店

B. SPECIALISED BOUTIQUES

7. **bridal boutique — 婚紗精品店**

Practice 1

> She booked an appointment at a **bridal boutique**.

她在一家**婚紗精品店**預約了試身。

Practice 2

> Bridal boutiques often offer fitting appointments.

婚紗精品店通常提供預約試身服務。

8. **jewellery boutique — 珠寶精品店**

Practice 1

> The hotel lobby contains a small **jewellery boutique**.

酒店大堂內有一間小型**珠寶精品店**。

Practice 2

> The boutique specialises in handmade jewellery.

這間精品店專售**手工珠寶**。

9. **shoe boutique — 鞋履精品店**

Practice 1

> The **shoe boutique** carries several European labels.

這間**鞋履精品店**出售多個歐洲品牌。

Practice 2

> She found the boots at a small shoe boutique.

她在一間小型**鞋履精品店**找到那雙靴。

10. **children's boutique — 兒童精品店**

Practice 1

> The children's boutique sells clothes and gifts.

這間**兒童精品店**出售服裝和禮品。

Practice 2

> Small boutiques often target a specific customer group.

小型精品店往往針對特定顧客群。

C. ONLINE BOUTIQUE

11. **online boutique — 網上精品店**

A natural modern extension.

Practice 1

> She runs an **online boutique** selling vintage clothing.

她經營一間出售復古服裝的**網上精品店**。

Practice 2

> Online boutiques can offer niche products without operating a physical shop.

網上精品店可以在沒有實體店的情況下出售小眾產品。

MCQ-ready definition:

online boutique = 以精品店形式經營、通常出售時尚或精選商品的網上商店

12. **physical boutique / brick-and-mortar boutique — 實體精品店**

Your passage says:

> **physical boutique**

to contrast it with online shopping.

Practice 1

> Customers can try items on in a **physical boutique**.

顧客可以在**實體精品店**試穿商品。

Practice 2

> The brand operates both an online store and several brick-and-mortar boutiques.

品牌同時經營網店和數間**實體精品店**。

Important distinction 1: **boutique vs online boutique**

Traditionally:

> boutique

strongly suggests a physical specialist shop.

But modern English freely uses:

> **online boutique**

So the physical location is no longer essential to the word itself.

That is why your passage explicitly says:

> **physical boutique**

to make the contrast completely clear.

D. BOUTIQUE = SMALL, SPECIALISED, DISTINCTIVE BUSINESS

This is the major figurative/commercial extension.

13. **boutique = small and highly specialised — 小型專門的；精品式的**

Before another business noun, **boutique** often no longer means “shop.”

It means:

a relatively small business that specialises narrowly and often offers personalised, high-skill or premium service

Practice 1

> They hired a **boutique consulting firm**.

他們聘請了一間**小型專業顧問公司**。

Practice 2

> She left a large corporation to join a boutique agency.

她離開大型企業，加入一家**小型專門代理公司**。

MCQ-ready definition:

boutique + business = 規模較小、專門化程度較高，通常提供個人化或高端服務的企業

14. **boutique firm — 精品式 / 小型專門公司**

Practice 1

> A **boutique firm** may focus on a narrow area of expertise.

小型專門公司可能集中於一個很窄的專業領域。

Practice 2

> The boutique firm works with only a small number of clients.

這間**精品式專業公司**只服務少量客戶。

15. **boutique consultancy / consulting firm — 精品顧問公司；小型專業顧問公司**

Practice 1

> The retailer hired a **boutique consultancy**.

零售商聘請了一間**小型專業顧問公司**。

Practice 2

> Boutique consultancies often specialise in one industry or problem type.

精品顧問公司往往專門處理某一行業或某類問題。

16. **boutique agency** — 精品代理公司；小型專業代理公司

Practice 1

> The campaign was created by a **boutique advertising agency**.

宣傳活動由一家**小型專業廣告公司**製作。

Practice 2

> Boutique agencies may offer more personalised attention.

精品式代理公司可能提供更個人化的服務。

E. BOUTIQUE LAW FIRM

17. **boutique law firm** — 精品律師事務所；小型專門律師事務所

A highly established professional-services use.

Practice 1

> The company hired a **boutique law firm** specialising in employment law.

公司聘請了一間專門處理僱傭法的**精品律師事務所**。

Practice 2

> Boutique firms may concentrate on a narrow legal practice area.

****專門型律師事務所**可能只集中於少數法律領域。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****boutique law firm = 規模通常較小、專門處理特定法律領域的律師事務所****

Important distinction 2: ****boutique firm does not necessarily mean cheap or small in expertise****

A boutique professional firm may be:

- * small in headcount,

- * narrow in focus,

but:

- * expensive,

- * prestigious,

- * highly specialised.

So:

boutique ≠ low-end.

Quite often it suggests the opposite:

specialist + premium.

F. BOUTIQUE FINANCE

18. ****boutique investment bank — 精品投資銀行；專門投資銀行****

A major finance compound.

Practice 1

> The transaction was advised by a ****boutique investment bank****.

交易由一家****精品投資銀行****提供顧問服務。

Practice 2

> Boutique investment banks often focus on advisory work or particular sectors.

****精品投資銀行**往往集中於顧問業務或特定行業。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****boutique investment bank = 規模較小或業務較集中、專門提供特定投資銀行服務的金融機構****

19. ****boutique advisory firm — 精品財務顧問公司****

Practice 1

> The founders hired a ****boutique advisory firm****.

創辦人聘請了一間****小型專業顧問公司****。

Practice 2

> The firm specialises in mergers and acquisitions.

該公司專門提供併購顧問服務。

20. ****boutique asset manager / investment firm — 精品資產管理 / 投資公司****

Practice 1

> The fund is managed by a ****boutique investment firm****.

基金由一家****精品投資公司****管理。

Practice 2

> Boutique asset managers may specialise in a limited number of strategies.

****精品資產管理公司**可能只專注少數投資策略。**

Important distinction 3: ****boutique investment bank vs retail bank****

****boutique investment bank****

specialist corporate finance/advisory institution.

****retail bank****

serves ordinary consumers with:

- * deposits,
- * cards,
- * loans,
- * mortgages, etc.

The word **boutique** here has nothing to do with selling fashionable goods.

G. BOUTIQUE HOTEL

21. **boutique hotel** — 精品酒店

One of the most important lexicalized compounds.

Practice 1

> They stayed at a small **boutique hotel**.

他們入住了一間小型**精品酒店**。

Practice 2

> The boutique hotel has individually designed rooms.

這間**精品酒店**的客房採用個別設計。

MCQ-ready definition:

boutique hotel = 通常規模較小、設計獨特並強調個性化服務和特色體驗的酒店

22. **boutique accommodation** — 精品式住宿

Practice 1

> The area has several forms of **boutique accommodation**.

該區有數間**精品式特色住宿**。

Practice 2

> Boutique accommodation often emphasises design and local character.

****精品式住宿**往往重視設計及地方特色。**

Important distinction 4: ****boutique hotel vs luxury hotel****

They overlap, but are not synonymous.

****boutique hotel****

emphasizes:

- * smaller scale,
- * individuality,
- * distinctive design,
- * personalised experience.

****luxury hotel****

emphasizes:

- * high standard,
- * premium facilities/service,
- * high-end comfort.

A hotel can be:

- * boutique but not extremely luxurious,
- * luxurious but large and not boutique,
- * both.

H. BOUTIQUE BRAND

23. ****boutique brand — 精品 / 小眾特色品牌****

Practice 1

> The shop carries several ****boutique brands****.

商店出售數個****小眾精品品牌****。

Practice 2

> Boutique brands often compete through design and identity rather than scale.

****精品品牌**往往靠設計和品牌特色，而不是規模競爭。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****boutique brand = 規模相對較小、定位獨特或較高端的小眾品牌****

24. ****boutique label — 精品 / 小眾品牌****

Especially fashion/music contexts.

Practice 1

> The designer launched a ****boutique fashion label****.

設計師推出了一個****小眾精品時裝品牌****。

Practice 2

> The boutique label produces limited collections.

這個****精品品牌****生產數量有限的系列。

I. BOUTIQUE PRODUCT / COLLECTION

25. ****boutique product — 精品式、小量專門產品****

Practice 1

> The company focuses on ****boutique products**** rather than mass-market goods.

公司集中生產****精品式產品****，而不是大眾市場商品。

Practice 2

> Boutique products may emphasise craftsmanship or exclusivity.

****精品產品****可能特別強調工藝或獨特性。

26. ****boutique collection — 精品系列；精選系列****

Practice 1

> The designer released a small ****boutique collection****.

設計師推出了一個小型****精品系列****。

Practice 2

> The collection targets customers looking for less mainstream styles.

這個系列針對尋找較非主流款式的顧客。

J. BOUTIQUE SERVICE

27. ****boutique service — 小型、高度個人化的專業服務****

Practice 1

> The agency offers a ****boutique service**** to a limited number of clients.

代理公司向少量客戶提供****高度個人化的精品式服務****。

Practice 2

> Boutique service usually emphasizes attention and specialisation.

****精品式服務****通常強調個人化關注和專門性。

28. ****boutique experience — 精品式 / 獨特個人化體驗****

Practice 1

> The retailer wants to recreate a ****boutique experience**** online.

零售商希望在網上重現****精品店式的個人化購物體驗****。

Practice 2

> Personal recommendations can create a more boutique experience.

個人化推薦可以營造更具****精品店特色的體驗****。

This is especially relevant to your fashion passage.

K. BOUTIQUE APPROACH

29. **boutique approach = small-scale, specialised, personalised approach — 精品式 / 專門化做法**

Practice 1

> The company takes a **boutique approach** to customer service.

公司採取**高度個人化的精品式客戶服務方式**。

Practice 2

> A boutique approach may be difficult to scale rapidly.

小規模專門化的服務模式可能較難迅速擴展。

MCQ-ready definition:

boutique approach = 以小規模、專門化和個人化為特色的做法

L. BOUTIQUE BUSINESS

30. **boutique business = small specialist business — 精品式 / 小型專門企業**

Practice 1

> It started as a **boutique business**.

它最初是一間**小型精品企業**。

Practice 2

> The business remained boutique even after gaining a strong reputation.

即使建立良好聲譽後，企業仍保持**小規模、專門化定位**。

Important distinction 5: **boutique = shop vs boutique = business style**

Retail noun:

> I went into a **boutique**.

> 我走進一間**精品店**。

Business modifier:

> a **boutique consultancy**

> 一間**小型專業顧問公司**

In the second case, there is no retail shop involved.

M. WHAT “BOUTIQUE” TENDS TO IMPLY

Across its extended uses, **boutique** commonly suggests some combination of:

1. **small scale**

not a huge mass-market operation.

2. **specialisation**

focused on a narrow product/service area.

3. **careful selection**

curated rather than enormous inventory.

4. **individuality**

distinctive style or identity.

5. **personal service**

more customised attention.

6. **premium positioning**

often, though not always, more expensive/high-end.

Important:

Not every use contains all six.

For example:

> boutique investment bank

strongly suggests specialization, but not necessarily fashionable design.

N. BOUTIQUE VS SHOP

Important distinction 6: **boutique vs shop**

shop

very broad BrE noun:

> any retail premises.

boutique

narrower:

> small, fashionable/specialised shop, often selling selected goods.

So:

> every fashion boutique is a shop

but:

> not every shop is a boutique.

O. BOUTIQUE VS STORE

Important distinction 7: **boutique vs store**

store

broad retail establishment, especially common in AmE.

Can be:

* tiny,

- * huge,
- * general,
- * specialist.

boutique

suggests:

- * smaller,
- * curated,
- * fashionable/specialist,
- * often more personal.

- > department store
- > large broad retailer

- > fashion boutique
- > smaller selected-fashion retailer

P. BOUTIQUE VS DEPARTMENT STORE

Important distinction 8: **boutique vs department store**

boutique

small and specialised.

department store

large store divided into many product departments.

Example:

- > A boutique may sell only designer womenswear.
- > A department store may sell clothing, cosmetics, furniture, electronics, etc.

This is a major scale/range contrast.

Q. BOUTIQUE VS CHAIN STORE

Important distinction 9: **boutique vs chain store**

boutique

often independent/distinctive.

chain store

one outlet belonging to a larger standardized retail chain.

However:

boutiques can belong to chains too.

A luxury brand may operate:

> hundreds of branded boutiques.

So:

boutique ≠ necessarily independent.

R. BOUTIQUE VS OUTLET

Important distinction 10: **boutique vs outlet**

boutique

usually emphasises presentation, fashion and selected merchandise.

outlet / outlet store

often sells:

- * discounted goods,
- * past-season goods,
- * surplus goods,

depending on brand/business model.

A:

> designer boutique

and:

> designer outlet

can offer very different shopping experiences.

S. BOUTIQUE VS SHOWROOM

Important distinction 11: **boutique vs showroom**

boutique

primarily retail shop where products are sold.

showroom

space primarily designed to display products for inspection/demonstration.

A showroom may or may not complete retail sales directly.

T. BOUTIQUE VS FLAGSHIP STORE

Important distinction 12: **boutique vs flagship store**

boutique

small/specialist/style-oriented.

flagship store

brand's most prominent/prestigious store.

A flagship can be:

- * enormous,
- * highly elaborate.

A brand may call a smaller luxury store a boutique, but the concepts are not synonyms.

U. BOUTIQUE VS SPECIALTY SHOP

Important distinction 13: ****boutique vs specialty/specialist shop****

****specialty shop****

focuses on a specific product category.

****boutique****

adds possible associations of:

- * fashion,
- * style,
- * curated selection,
- * premium identity.

A specialist hardware shop is:

> a specialty shop

but would not normally be called:

> a boutique

unless used playfully/marketing-wise.

V. BOUTIQUE VS LUXURY

Important distinction 14: ****boutique does not automatically mean luxury****

A boutique may be:

- * affordable,
- * mid-range,
- * luxury.

The word primarily suggests:

****small + specialised/curated****

not automatically:

****very expensive****.

However, luxury association is common.

W. BOUTIQUE VS DESIGNER

Important distinction 15: **boutique vs designer**

boutique

type/style of retailer.

designer

product associated with a recognized fashion designer or designer brand.

A boutique can sell:

- * designer clothing,
- * independent clothing,
- * inexpensive niche clothing.

A designer brand can sell through:

- * boutiques,
- * department stores,
- * online retailers.

X. BOUTIQUE VS NICHE

From your already-curated **niche** family:

niche

serves a narrow market/need.

boutique

often combines niche specialization with:

- * small scale,
- * curated experience,
- * personalised service.

A business can be:

> niche but large

or:

> boutique and niche.

They frequently overlap.

Y. BOUTIQUE VS INDEPENDENT

Important distinction 16: **boutique vs independent**

independent

not controlled by a larger chain/group.

boutique

small/specialised/curated.

A boutique may be owned by:

> a global luxury company.

Therefore:

boutique ≠ independent.

Z. BOUTIQUE VS PREMIUM

Important distinction 17: **boutique vs premium**

premium

higher quality/price/status positioning.

boutique

smaller, specialised, distinctive.

A large global company can offer a:

> premium service

without being boutique.

AA. BOUTIQUE HOTEL VS SMALL HOTEL

Important distinction 18: ****boutique hotel vs small hotel****

A hotel is not automatically “boutique” merely because it has few rooms.

The phrase usually implies some combination of:

- * distinctive design,
- * individuality,
- * character,
- * personalised service,
- * non-standardised experience.

So:

> small hotel ≠ automatically boutique hotel.

AB. BOUTIQUE FIRM VS SMALL FIRM

Important distinction 19: ****boutique firm vs small firm****

****small firm****

only tells us about scale.

****boutique firm****

typically adds:

- * narrow expertise,
- * specialist positioning,
- * personalised client service,
- * sometimes prestige.

Therefore:

> boutique = more semantic content than merely “small.”

AC. BOUTIQUE SERVICE VS MASS-MARKET SERVICE

Important distinction 20: **boutique vs mass-market**

boutique

- * fewer clients/products,
- * more specialization,
- * individuality,
- * personalised attention.

mass-market

- * large volume,
- * broad audience,
- * standardisation,
- * scalability.

Your passage's fictional company **Fast Fashion** sounds much closer to:

> mass-market online retail

than a traditional:

> physical boutique.

This contrast helps explain why the writer deliberately chooses **boutique**.

AD. BOUTIQUE AND “CURATED”

A useful semantic distinction:

boutique

describes the shop/business style.

curated

describes the selection:

> deliberately and carefully chosen.

Boutiques often have:

> a curated selection

but the two words are not synonyms.

AE. BOUTIQUE AND PERSONAL SERVICE

The word often carries an implication of:

> more individual attention.

For example:

> a boutique law firm

> a boutique hotel

> a boutique fashion shop

may all suggest:

fewer clients/customers + more tailored attention.

But this is an implication, not a strict dictionary requirement.

AF. BOUTIQUE AS MARKETING LANGUAGE

Modern businesses sometimes use ****boutique**** very loosely as promotional language:

> boutique gym

> boutique fitness studio

> boutique travel company

> boutique agency

> boutique consultancy

Here it often signals:

****small + stylish + specialised + personalised****

Sometimes the word is mainly branding rather than an objective technical category.

31. **boutique fitness studio — 精品健身工作室**

Practice 1

> She joined a **boutique fitness studio** specialising in Pilates.

她加入了一間專門教授 Pilates 的**精品健身工作室**。

Practice 2

> Boutique fitness studios often run smaller classes.

精品健身工作室往往提供較小班教學。

32. **boutique travel company — 精品旅遊公司**

Practice 1

> The trip was arranged by a **boutique travel company**.

旅程由一家**小型特色旅遊公司**安排。

Practice 2

> Boutique operators may focus on highly customised itineraries.

精品式旅遊營辦商可能專門提供高度個人化行程。

33. **boutique studio — 精品工作室；小型專業工作室**

Practice 1

> The project was produced by a **boutique design studio**.

項目由一間**小型專業設計工作室**製作。

Practice 2

> A boutique studio may deliberately remain small.

****精品式工作室**可能刻意維持小規模。**

AG. COUNTABILITY

Important distinction 21: ****boutique is countable as a shop****

Natural:

- > a boutique
- > two boutiques
- > several boutiques

Practice

> The neighbourhood has many independent ****boutiques****.

該區有很多獨立****精品店****。

When used attributively:

- > boutique hotel
- > boutique firm

****boutique**** does not take plural ****s**** because it is modifying another noun.

Correct:

> three boutique hotels 

not:

> *three boutiques hotels* 

AH. ARTICLE USE

Use:

> ****a boutique****

when referring to one shop.

> She works in ****a boutique****.

Use no article when it modifies another noun:

> She works for **a boutique consultancy**.

Here the article belongs to:

> consultancy,

not to boutique separately.

AI. "BOUTIQUE" AS AN ATTRIBUTIVE NOUN VS TRUE ADJECTIVE

Traditional grammatical analysis often treats:

> boutique hotel

> boutique firm

as **noun + noun compounds**, with **boutique** used attributively.

Modern dictionaries may also describe this extended use adjectivally.

For learners, the practical point is:

boutique can naturally appear before another noun and mean "small, specialised, distinctive/premium."

AJ. REGISTER

Boutique is normal modern English but often carries a slightly:

* stylish,

* commercial,

* upscale,

* marketing-oriented

tone.

Compare:

> small hotel

> plain factual

- > boutique hotel
- > adds positioning/style.

- > small consultancy
- > scale only

- > boutique consultancy
- > specialised/personalised positioning.

AK. PASSAGE-SPECIFIC CONTRAST: BOUTIQUE VS ONLINE SHOP

Your passage says:

- > Unlike shoppers in a physical **boutique**, our customers cannot try on a dress, feel the fabric or compare two sizes in front of a mirror.

This works because **boutique** evokes a particularly tactile fashion-shopping experience:

Physical boutique:

- * garment physically present,
- * fitting possible,
- * fabric can be touched,
- * mirror available,
- * sizes can be compared,
- * assistance may be available.

Online store:

- * relies on photos,
- * written descriptions,
- * size charts,
- * delivery accuracy.

The writer therefore uses the boutique comparison to justify:

- > **a fairer returns policy**

because online shoppers accept more uncertainty before purchase.

Important distinction 22: **boutique** does not itself mean “physical”

This is important.

Because English has:

> **online boutique**

the writer says:

> **physical boutique**

to specify a brick-and-mortar retail environment.

Without **physical**, the noun by itself might still strongly suggest a shop, but modern usage no longer guarantees that distinction.

AL. PASSAGE-SPECIFIC: WHY “BOUTIQUE” RATHER THAN “SHOP”?

The writer could have said:

> physical shop.

But **boutique** is more semantically precise because the item is:

> fashion.

A boutique naturally suggests:

- * clothing,
- * trying on garments,
- * presentation,
- * selected styles,
- * personal inspection.

So it helps make the online-shopping disadvantage vivid:

> in a boutique, you can inspect **fit + fabric + colour + appearance** before paying.

AM. “BOUTIQUE” AND FAST FASHION

There is an interesting contrast inside the passage:

boutique

often evokes:

- * small-scale,
- * curated,
- * personal,
- * specialist shopping.

fast fashion

often evokes:

- * high volume,
- * rapid turnover,
- * online scale,
- * standardized processes.

The letter uses the **boutique experience** as the physical-shopping benchmark that online fast-fashion customers do **not** receive.

Therefore the company may need to compensate for that missing pre-purchase experience with:

> a more proportionate post-purchase returns system.

Family-extension note

The **boutique** family is morphologically small but has several strong modern semantic branches:

1. **fashion retail shop**

- * boutique
- * fashion boutique
- * designer boutique

2. **specialist retail**

- * bridal boutique
- * jewellery boutique
- * shoe boutique

3. **ownership/business format**

* independent boutique

4. **digital retail**

* online boutique

5. **physical retail**

* physical boutique

* brick-and-mortar boutique

6. **small specialist professional company**

* boutique firm

* boutique consultancy

* boutique agency

7. **legal services**

* boutique law firm

8. **finance**

* boutique investment bank

* boutique investment firm

9. **hospitality**

* boutique hotel

* boutique accommodation

10. **branding**

* boutique brand

* boutique label

11. **premium/specialised products**

* boutique product

* boutique collection

12. **personalised service**

* boutique service

* boutique experience

13. **business strategy**

* boutique approach

14. **modern marketing extensions**

* boutique fitness studio

* boutique travel company

* boutique design studio

For your passage, the exact branch is:

boutique = a relatively small, specialised fashion shop where customers can physically inspect and try on clothing before buying

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
-----	-----	-----	
boutique	精品店；時裝精品店	passage sense	
fashion boutique	時裝精品店	clothing	
clothing boutique	服裝精品店	clothing	
designer boutique	設計師精品店	designer fashion	
luxury boutique	奢侈品精品店	high-end retail	
independent boutique	獨立精品店	independent retail	
bridal boutique	婚紗精品店	specialist retail	
jewellery boutique	珠寶精品店	specialist retail	
shoe boutique	鞋履精品店	specialist retail	
online boutique	網上精品店	e-commerce	
physical boutique	實體精品店	passage	
brick-and-mortar boutique	實體精品店	physical retail	
boutique firm	小型專門公司	professional services	
boutique consultancy	精品 / 小型專業顧問公司	consulting	
boutique agency	小型專業代理公司	agency	
boutique law firm	精品律師事務所	law	
boutique investment bank	精品投資銀行	finance	
boutique advisory firm	精品顧問公司	finance	
boutique investment firm	精品投資公司	investment	
boutique hotel	精品酒店	hospitality	
boutique accommodation	精品式住宿	hospitality	
boutique brand	精品 / 小眾品牌	branding	
boutique label	精品 / 小眾品牌	fashion/music	
boutique product	精品式產品	product	
boutique collection	精品系列	fashion	

boutique service	精品式個人化服務	service	
boutique experience	精品式體驗	customer experience	
boutique approach	小型專門化做法	strategy	
boutique business	精品式小型企業	business model	
boutique fitness studio	精品健身工作室	modern extension	
boutique travel company	精品旅遊公司	specialist service	
boutique studio	精品式 / 小型專業工作室	creative services	

For your original sentence

> Unlike shoppers in a physical ****boutique****, our customers cannot try on a dress, feel the fabric or compare two sizes in front of a mirror.

Here:

****boutique = 一間規模通常較小、專門出售時裝或精選服飾，並讓顧客可以親自查看和試穿商品的精品店****

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 與在實體****時裝精品店****購物的顧客不同，我們的網上顧客不能試穿裙子、觸摸布料，或在鏡子前比較兩個尺碼。

The cleanest learner contrast is:

- > ****shop/store**** = 最廣義的商店
- > ****boutique**** = ****小型、時尚、專門 / 精選的精品店****
- > ****specialty shop**** = 專售某類商品的專門店
- > ****department store**** = 大型百貨公司
- > ****chain store**** = 連鎖店
- > ****outlet**** = 特賣 / 折扣門市等零售據點
- > ****showroom**** = 以展示商品為主的陳列空間
- > ****flagship store**** = 品牌最重要、最具代表性的旗艦店
- > ****luxury**** = 高端昂貴，不等於 boutique
- > ****niche**** = 針對狹窄市場，不一定小型或高端

And the key polysemy leap is:

- > ****fashion boutique**** = 精品店
- > ****boutique hotel**** = ****小型、有特色、個人化的精品酒店****
- > ****boutique law firm**** = ****小型而高度專門的律師事務所****
- > ****boutique investment bank**** = ****規模較小、業務高度專門化的投資銀行****

So across these uses, the semantic core is not simply ****“fashionable.”**** It is closer to:

small-scale + specialised + carefully positioned + often more individualised than a mass-market operation.